

Hunger isn't the story. It's where the story starts.

Why an anti-violence organization sits at the table at this year's Philadelphia Food Summit — and what it says about us.

BY ERICKA GAINES

When people hear that an anti-violence organization helped build a food summit, they tend to ask some version of the same question: what does feeding people have to do with stopping violence?

It's a fair question. It's also the whole point.

For as long as we've been working in Philadelphia neighborhoods, violence has been the headline. It's what brings the news van, the press conference, the vigil on the corner. But violence is rarely where the story begins. By the time it reaches a headline, the story is already near its end. The earlier chapters, the ones nobody sees, are quieter.

They're usually about scarcity: an empty cabinet; a child trying to learn on a loud, empty stomach; a parent running budgets that never add up while the bills always do. They're forced to make hard choices. Choices no one should have to make. Rent or groceries. The electric bill or dinner.

Hunger isn't the story. It's where the story starts.

In one of the most abundant food regions in the country, more than 270,000 Philadelphians don't know where their next meal is coming from. That's not a footnote to the city's other struggles. It's the soil they grow in.

You can't understand a city's hardest outcomes without reckoning with its most basic ones. When you can't eat, everything is harder. School. Work. Health. Patience. Hope.

Stress builds. Stability? None. The conditions that make violence more likely are usually the very conditions that leave families hungry: disinvestment, isolation, and the slow decline of the things a community needs to hold itself together. We've learned, often the hard way, that you don't change those conditions by reacting after the damage is done. You change them upstream — and there's nowhere further upstream than whether a family can eat.

That's why we showed up to the Philadelphia Food Summit on June 5th at Temple University — and why we helped build it. The summit asked one simple question: *will you be at the table?*

We gathered everyone in a room: grassroots organizers, advocates, funders, farmers, business owners, government, and the residents living these realities every day. One purpose: to break down the silos keeping the people working on these problems separated.

The table has two meanings. There's the table where a family sits down to eat, the most ordinary measure of whether a household is okay. Then there's the table where decisions get made about which households get to be okay. For too long, the people closest to hunger have been kept from the second table while being left to survive the absence of the first. That's what this summit set out to change.

So what does an anti-violence organization bring to that table? A perspective the room needs: *food work is prevention*; food security and community safety aren't separate problems — they share the same roots.

Every meal that reliably reaches a family is an eased pressure: one less stress on a household; a child more focused on their future than a growling stomach; less contention over scarcity and happier, more peaceful homes. Steady food access won't end harm on its own, but it strengthens the foundations that make harm less likely. So when we show up to talk about food, we're not talking about an issue. We're attacking it at the root.

Showing up here is a refusal to stay in the silos that have failed this city for decades. Philadelphia's problems don't respect org charts. Hunger, violence, health, housing, opportunity — they're tied together on the same blocks, the same families, often on the same day. Ignoring that is comfortable, that's why so little changes.

We'd rather pull up a chair at an unfamiliar table than keep trying to solve our slice of the problem alone.

None of this gets solved on a single Friday, but the Summit was never meant to be one. June 5th is a starting line, not a finish: the point is what we build after it. The relationships that outlast the room. The connections and coordination that turn one gathering into lasting partnerships. The shared resolve to keep showing up for one another long after the chairs are stacked. A crisis won't get fixed at an event; it gets fixed by solving the problem together. That ongoing work, not the day, is the movement this Summit aims to start.

If you care about this city — its safety, its children, its future — there is a seat for you. Not at that table alone — but at every one that gets built after.

Hunger is where the story starts. How it ends depends on who keeps showing up.

We'll see you at the table.

Ericka Gaines is Director of Community Empowerment at the Anti-Violence Partnership of Philadelphia.

The 2026 Philadelphia Food Summit took place Friday, June 5, at Temple University's Howard Gittis Student Center. Learn more at phillyfoodsummit.org — and support the ongoing work at [the summit's donation page](#).